Story skeleton

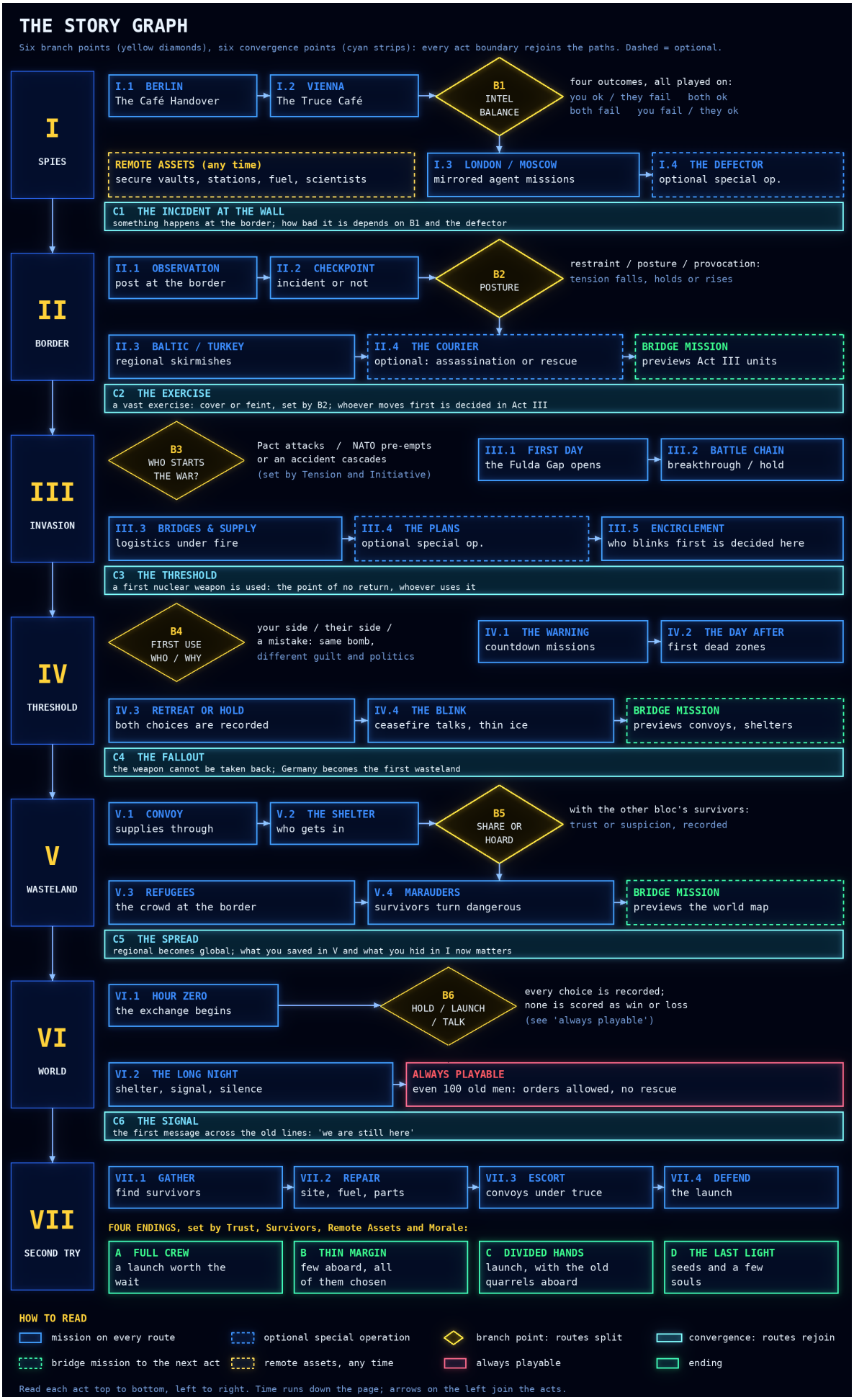
Summary. This is the fixed frame of the campaign: seven acts, six branch points, six convergence points and four endings. It decides *where the story can go* and what each result routes to, but not what any single mission contains. Every act boundary is a convergence point, so the paths always rejoin and the number of missions stays manageable. Both blocs play the same graph in mirrored form, and neither is favoured. It is a proposal for you to lock, change or reject one branch point at a time. No code exists, and none will start before the new repository is created.

Principles of the skeleton

- **A braid, not a tree.** Branches happen inside an act and rejoin at its end, so every path reaches every act. The differences carry forward as state, not as separate stories.
- **Every mission continues the story,** whatever the result. No result ends the campaign, and every route can reach the colony ship in Act VII.
- **Both sides, equal chances.** The graph is the same for the West and the East. Either bloc can be the aggressor at B3, and absent a decisive imbalance both end up in the same place.
- **Consequences are felt later, not reported.** A branch changes the next missions, through intel, morale, supply and who trusts whom.
- **The war is hard to stop, and that is the point.** De-escalation can work for a while, but every success is fragile (see decision D1).
- **The results of the war are never a joke.** Everything around them can be, and the humour gets drier as the stakes rise, until the ending, which is sincere.
- **Enemies are people,** with names and small human details, and the game resists the official line of both blocs.

State variables that routes depend on

Variable	Meaning	Moves with
Tension	How close the blocs are to war	Incidents, posture, provocation, spy results
Initiative	Who is better placed to strike first	Exercises, readiness, intel balance, who was provoked
Escalation	How far weapons have gone (conventional, tactical nuclear, strategic)	Battle results, political support, who blinks
Intel balance	How much each side knows of the other	Spy missions, agents, the enemy's losses (partial and ageing)
Trust	Trust between and inside the blocs	Honest dealing, shared supplies, civilian harm, defections
Home front and political support	What the public and leaders will allow	Casualties, news, results, leaks
Force and morale	Surviving units, veterans, equipment and their morale	Every mission result, rest, supply, reserves
Civilian harm	How much damage was done to the people caught in it	Methods chosen in missions and at branch points
Ark assets	Things secured in remote places (seed vault, polar station, fuel, aircraft, scientists)	Optional remote-asset orders from Act I on
Survivors	People who live to Act VII	Shelter, sharing, evacuation, what you did in Act VI


THE STORY GRAPH
Six branch points (yellow diamonds), six convergence points (cyan strips): every act boundary rejoins the paths. Dashed = optional.
I
SPIES
I.1 BERLIN
The Café Handover
I.2 VIENNA
The Truce Café
B1
INTEL
BALANCE
four outcomes, all played on:
you ok / they fail
both ok
both fail
you fail / they ok
REMOTE ASSETS (any time)
secure vaults, stations, fuel, scientists
I.3 LONDON / MOSCOW
mirrored agent missions
I.4 THE DEFECTOR
optional special op.
C1 THE INCIDENT AT THE WALL
something happens at the border; how bad it is depends on B1 and the defector
II
BORDER
II.1 OBSERVATION
post at the border
II.2 CHECKPOINT
incident or not
B2
POSTURE
restraint / posture / provocation:
tension falls, holds or rises
II.3 BALTIC / TURKEY
regional skirmishes
II.4 THE COURIER
optional: assassination or rescue
BRIDGE MISSION
previews Act III units
C2 THE EXERCISE
a vast exercise: cover or feint, set by B2; whoever moves first is decided in Act III
III
INVASION
B3
WHO STARTS
THE WAR?
Pact attacks / NATO pre-empts
or an accident cascades
(set by Tension and Initiative)
III.1 FIRST DAY
the Fulda Gap opens
III.2 BATTLE CHAIN
breakthrough / hold
III.3 BRIDGES & SUPPLY
logistics under fire
III.4 THE PLANS
optional special op.
III.5 ENCIRCLEMENT
who blinks first is decided here
C3 THE THRESHOLD
a first nuclear weapon is used: the point of no return, whoever uses it
IV
THRESHOLD
B4
FIRST USE
WHO / WHY
your side / their side /
a mistake: same bomb,
different guilt and politics
IV.1 THE WARNING
countdown missions
IV.2 THE DAY AFTER
first dead zones
IV.3 RETREAT OR HOLD
both choices are recorded
IV.4 THE BLINK
ceasefire talks, thin ice
BRIDGE MISSION
previews convoys, shelters
C4 THE FALLOUT
the weapon cannot be taken back; Germany becomes the first wasteland
V
WASTELAND
V.1 CONVOY
supplies through
V.2 THE SHELTER
who gets in
B5
SHARE OR
HOARD
with the other bloc's survivors:
trust or suspicion, recorded
V.3 REFUGEES
the crowd at the border
V.4 MARAUDERS
survivors turn dangerous
BRIDGE MISSION
previews the world map
C5 THE SPREAD
regional becomes global; what you saved in V and what you hid in I now matters
VI
WORLD
VI.1 HOUR ZERO
the exchange begins
B6
HOLD / LAUNCH
/ TALK
every choice is recorded;
none is scored as win or loss
(see 'always playable')
VI.2 THE LONG NIGHT
shelter, signal, silence
ALWAYS PLAYABLE
even 100 old men: orders allowed, no rescue
C6 THE SIGNAL
the first message across the old lines: 'we are still here'
VII
SECOND TRY
VII.1 GATHER
find survivors
VII.2 REPAIR
site, fuel, parts
VII.3 ESCORT
convoys under truce
VII.4 DEFEND
the launch
FOUR ENDINGS, set by Trust, Survivors, Remote Assets and Morale:
A FULL CREW
a launch worth the wait
B THIN MARGIN
few aboard, all of them chosen
C DIVIDED HANDS
launch, with the old quarrels aboard
D THE LAST LIGHT
seeds and a few souls
HOW TO READ
mission on every route
optional special operation
branch point: routes split
convergence: routes rejoin
bridge mission to the next act
remote assets, any time
always playable
ending
Read each act top to bottom, left to right. Time runs down the page; arrows on the left join the acts.

The six branch points

	Question	Decided by	Routes	What changes afterwards
B1 (Act I)	Who knows more about whom?	The double spy mission and how earlier agents fared	You succeed, they fail / both succeed / both fail / you fail, they succeed	Starting intel and ambush risk in Act II; how tense the border is
B2 (Act II)	How do you behave at the border?	Rules of engagement you choose, B1, home front	Restraint / posture / provocation	Tension, and whether the exercise at C2 is a cover or a feint
B3 (Act III)	Who starts the war?	Tension, Initiative, the exercise, your decisions	The East attacks / the West pre-empts / an accident cascades	Which side holds the first-day advantage; who is defending; the tone of the early battles
B4 (Act IV)	Who uses the first nuclear weapon, and why?	Battle results (who blinks), political support, escalation, trust	Your side / their side / a mistake or a rogue commander	Guilt and politics afterwards, how fast the fallout spreads
B5 (Act V)	Do you share or hoard?	Supplies, morale, trust, the refugees at the door	Share / split / hoard	Trust, number of survivors, who stands beside you in Act VII
B6 (Act VI)	Hold fire, launch or talk?	What is left to you; the choices are never scored as win or loss	Hold / launch / open talks	Trust and survivors; the tone of Act VII

The six convergence points

	Name	What is guaranteed whatever the route
C1	The incident at the wall	Something happens at the border. Its size and who is blamed depend on B1 and the defector
C2	The exercise	A vast exercise starts near the border. It is either cover for an attack or a feint, depending on B2
C3	The threshold	A first nuclear weapon is used. Who uses it, and why, is decided at B4
C4	The fallout	The weapon cannot be taken back, and Germany becomes the first wasteland
C5	The spread	The regional war becomes global. What you saved in Act V, and what you hid from Act I on, now matters
C6	The signal	The first message crosses the old lines: 'we are still here'. Act VII begins

Act by act

Act	Setting and look	Missions (est.)	Optional and bridge missions	Humour register
I Spies	Berlin, Vienna, London, Moscow, Geneva; painted close view, 4 to 8 agents	8 to 10	The defector; remote-asset orders at any time	Playful: cover identities, the cheese inspector, the truce café
II Border	Fulda sector, the Baltic, Turkey; terrain map, platoons and single vehicles	8	The courier (assassination or rescue); a bridge mission previewing Act III	Dry: the checkpoint paperwork, the weather report
III Invasion	The Fulda Gap; hex map, platoons and companies	10 to 12	The plans (special op.)	Gallows: the Ministry of Optimism, 'supplies are ambitious'
IV Threshold	Contested zones; operational map with warnings	6	A bridge mission previewing convoys and shelters	Very dark and dry; the narrator keeps explaining how to stay calm
V Wasteland	Germany contaminated; survival map, convoys and shelters	8	A bridge mission previewing the world map	Human: the mandatory-fun officer's talent show; never about the dead
VI World	Defcon-like world map; assets, not units	3 to 4	None. This act is always playable	Black: the DJ reads dedications and the weather of places that have none
VII Second Try	A launch site and the world logistics map; former enemies work together	6	None	Warm: the naming committee, the seating dispute. The last joke is sincere

Special operations in the middle acts

- **The defector (I.4):** protect or hand over. The choice changes Trust and the size of the incident at C1.
- **The courier (II.4):** an assassination attempt on a political or military figure, or the chance to rescue him. It can delay or trigger escalation, and it carries moral weight: neither choice is made easy, and the story shows what each one costs.
- **The plans (III.4):** steal or protect invasion plans, in the painted Commandos-style view, with a result that feeds the first days of the battle chain.

Bridge missions

My decision, as you left it to me: the acts stay clean and separate in their gameplay, and each act ends with one short bridge mission that previews the next act's units and look, so the change of scale is introduced and not sudden.

Remote assets

From Act I the player may send agents or small assets anywhere on the global map. Each of the following is a long-term investment that pays off in Act VII: a seed vault, a polar station, fuel caches, a few aircraft, scientists, a library, a hospital ship. Nothing is announced when they are placed. The enemy may find them, which makes them risky.

The four endings

	Name	Determined by	What it is
A	Full crew	High Trust, many survivors, most remote assets intact, steady morale	A launch worth the wait
B	Thin margin	Few survivors but good Trust and assets	Few aboard, every one of them chosen
C	Divided hands	Low Trust, mixed survivors and assets	The ship launches, with the old quarrels aboard
D	The last light	Very few survivors, assets partly lost	Seeds and a few souls: the smallest possible launch

All four end with the ship leaving, because Act VII is always possible. What differs is who is aboard, and what the last scene says about how they got there.

Recurring cast (neutral, one on each side)

- **The handler:** a dry, tired voice who briefs you in every act and is never fooled by the paperwork.
- **The counterpart:** a rival agent on the other side whom you meet at the Vienna truce café. They return in later acts as an enemy, a source and finally, depending on Trust, a partner in Act VII. This is where the 'trust seed' is planted.
- **Mr. Hendricks from Accounting:** audits your expenses in every act, even after the bombs, and becomes the most necessary person alive. A matching auditor exists on the other side.
- **The DJ:** the radio voice of Act VI, reading dedications.
- **The mandatory-fun officer:** runs the shelter's talent show in Act V.
- **The defector and the courier:** people, not symbols, with names and small human details.

Mirror structure

	West campaign	East campaign
Same	The graph, branch points, state variables and endings	The graph, branch points, state variables and endings
Tools	Alliance cohesion, air power, public opinion	Discipline, mass, central control, the weight of the party line
Texture	The press, committees, coalition friction	Reports that say what they must, quotas, the informant on every floor
Humour	Bureaucratic and self-satisfied	Bureaucratic and fearful. Different shape, same target: institutions, never the dead

Volume and effort (honest estimate)

- About 50 missions per playthrough, at 30 to 60 minutes each: roughly 25 to 45 hours.
- Branches add variants, not whole new stories. I'd expect about 70 authored missions per side, with around 60% of the content shared by both sides.
- The skeleton is data, so every route can be walked by an automated test that checks no path dead-ends and Act VII is always reachable.

Decisions I need from you

	Decision	My proposal
D1	Can the war be avoided entirely?	No. De-escalation can delay it and change its shape, but each success is fragile. This fits 'thin ice' and 'show how brutal war is'. The alternative is one rare hidden path that avoids it.
D2	Is 'an accident cascades' a good third answer at B3?	Yes. It is the most thematic one: nobody wanted this, and everybody is to blame.
D3	How hard should the courier mission (II.4) push the moral weight?	Both choices have clear costs. A refusal is also an option, and has its own.
D4	Are four endings right?	Four is enough, because Act VII always ends in a launch.
D5	Which remote assets, and does each unlock something in Act VII?	Seven types as above, each adding something specific to the ship.
D6	Are bridge missions at the end of Acts II, IV and V a good idea?	Yes; Acts I, III, VI and VII lead straight on.
D7	Should the first mission stay Berlin, with the West first?	Yes, with the East as a mirrored switch.
D8	Which of the six branch points do you want to change first?	Your call. B3 and B4 matter most for tone.

What this means for the vertical slice

The slice mission, 'The Café Handover', is node I.1 of the graph. Its outcomes route to I.2 and feed B1, so the interlude after it already has a real place in the story.

A reminder

The new repository still has to be created before any development work. Documents, graphs and mock-ups can continue until then.